journalists – found this very difficult to accept, and the effects of this non-acceptance of reality had prevailed for several years, leading to the willingness of the Pakistani population to support a tough campaign against the militants. This also led to the repeated attempts by the military and politicians to make peace deals with the TTP, the futility of which is cleverly dissected in this book.

As Mr Elahi writes, however, in early 2009, when the Pakistani security establishment recognised the TTP as a real threat to Pakistan's interests and even its survival as a state (as opposed to the misguided products of legitimate anti-American feelings), they successfully launched a series of operations against the militants to rally public opinion in support of these campaigns over time. Consequently, the Pakistani state and military were greatly helped by the atrocities committed by the TTP against Pakistanis, culminating in the massacre of schoolchildren in Peshawar. Eventually, it simply became impossible not to attribute these crimes to the TTP and its leadership.

This book brings out two more things that are important for both Pakistani and foreign observers to recognise. The first is that in the fight against the TTP insurgency, Pakistan had – for a while, and hopefully forever – won. This is despite what Mr Elahi says have been the often appalling failures of the Pakistani state and military response, especially regarding the development of a coherent, comprehensive counter-terrorism strategy as well as steady, institutionalised cooperation between Pakistan's disparate and often feuding security institutions.

This failure meant that Pakistan has suffered many unnecessary losses in the struggle against militancy, and that it had to rely on massive military operations – inevitably causing much civilian suffering – which could have rendered the previously planned intelligence police operations unnecessary.

The rebellion, which at one stage controlled a large majority of FATA and parts of North-West Frontier Province (NWFP), has nonetheless been defeated, and the TTP forces killed, captured or dispersed. The reason for the existence of TTP leadership and most of the surviving rank and file in Afghanistan is that they have been driven out of Pakistan.

As I wrote in my book, *Pakistan: A Hard Country*, which appeared in the middle of the struggle and predicted victory against the militants, Pakistan is tougher and more resilient than most observers – including many Pakistanis – have understood, and all those who wrote about